NOW SHOWING · MCCJ 527 ORGANIZED CRIME AND CORRUPTION

WAR DOGS

A Criminologist's Director's Cut

Three acts. Five crimes. One question: is this organized crime?



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Submitted to: Md. Rezaul Karim Shohag, Assistant Professor

A buddy comedy that hides a real organized fraud

DIRECTOR	Todd Phillips
YEAR · STUDIO	2016 · Warner Bros.
GENRE	Crime comedy-drama (based on true events)
STARRING	Jonah Hill · Miles Teller · Ana de Armas · Bradley Cooper
SOURCE	Guy Lawson, Rolling Stone (2011); Arms and the Dudes (2015)

OUR THESIS

Organized crime doesn't always carry guns. Sometimes it sells them, with a government contract.

$298M real Pentagon contract won by AEY Inc., 2007

Act I: two friends find gold in the Pentagon's "crumbs"

SCENE 1 · MIAMI

Broke and desperate

David, a massage therapist, fails selling bedsheets to care homes. His girlfriend is pregnant. He needs money fast.

SCENE 2 · AEY INC.

The crumbs

Old friend Efraim bids online for small military contracts that big firms ignore. David joins him.

SCENE 3 · IRAQ

The risky run

A stuck shipment of pistols is pushed through Jordan into Iraq with help from fixers. They get paid.

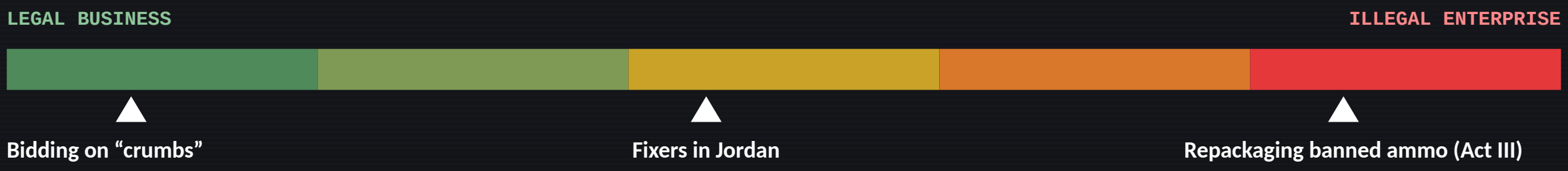
SCENE 4 · HIGH LIFE

Easy money

Bigger contracts, a new office, new cars. David starts hiding the truth from his partner, Iz.

"They don't fight the war. They just sell to it."

From legal bidding to grey deals: the enterprise model



Smith (1980): legal and illegal businesses sit on one spectrum and respond to the same market demand. AEY slides along it as profits grow.

Strain / anomie

Merton (1938); Messner & Rosenfeld (1994)

Broke with a baby on the way, David “innovates”: legitimate goal, illegitimate means.

Differential association

Sutherland (1940)

David learns the methods and the excuses of the trade from Efraim.

Rational choice

Cornish & Clarke (1986)

Each step is a calculation: big reward, small chance of being caught.

Act II: a broker, a Balkan stockpile and a $300M contract

SCENE 5 · VEGAS

The broker

At an arms fair they meet Henry Girard, a dealer on a terrorist watch list who cannot sell to the US directly.

SCENE 6 · ALBANIA

The stockpile

Henry opens access to about 100 million rounds of old rifle ammunition in Albania.

SCENE 7 · THE BID

The big one

With cheap supply and a financier, AEY underbids everyone and wins the Afghan army contract.

SCENE 8 · THE SPLIT

Who gets paid?

Efraim plans to cut Henry out of his share. Tension between the partners grows.

“Everybody in the chain takes a cut.”

The UN says yes. Abadinsky's mafia model says mostly no

UNTOC, ARTICLE 2 (UNODC, 2004)

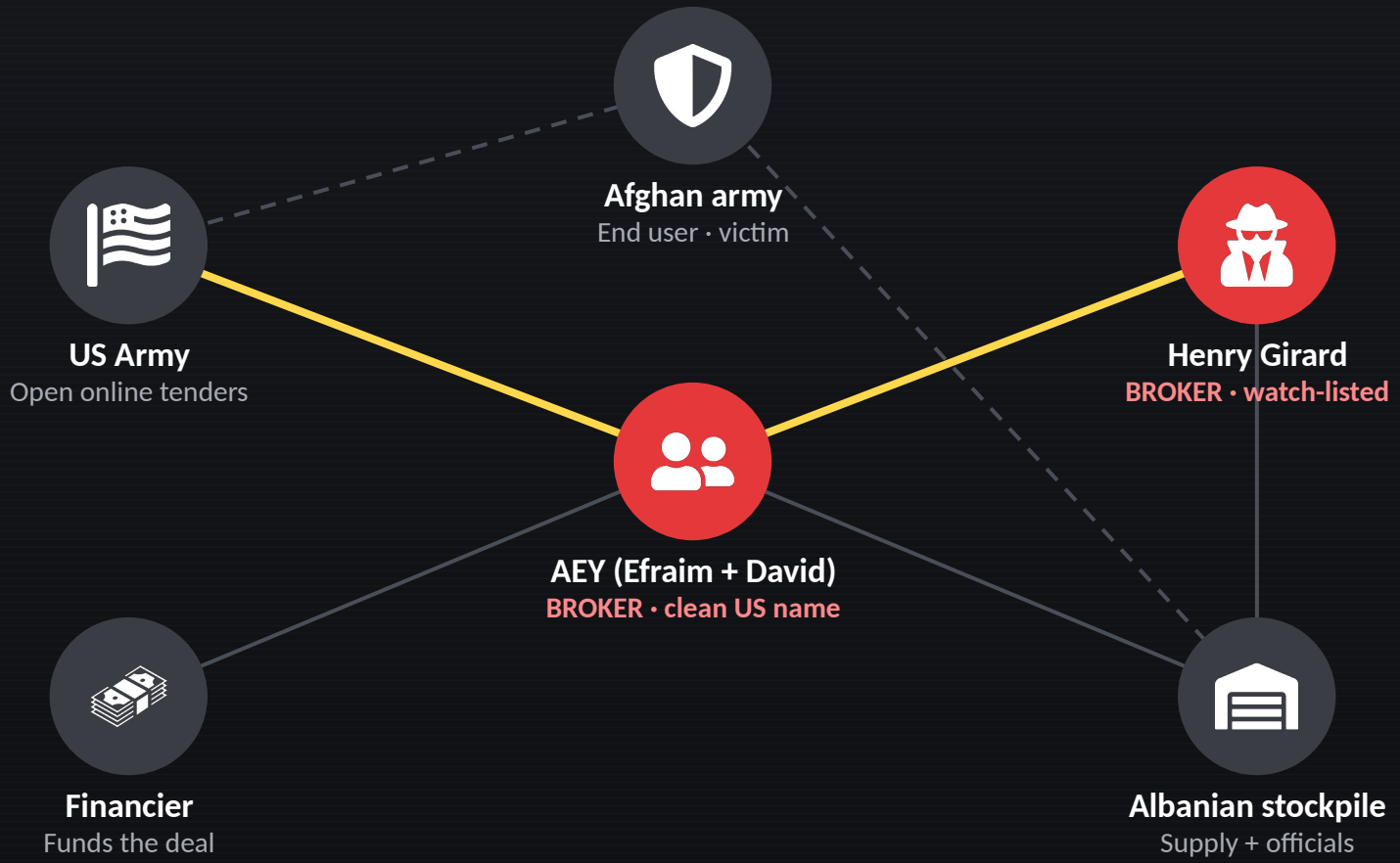
- ✓ **3+ persons in a structured group**
  Efraim, David, financier, Henry, suppliers
- ✓ **Existing for a period of time**
  Several years of operation
- ✓ **Committing serious crime**
  Fraud, conspiracy, embargo breach
- ✓ **For material benefit**
  Millions in profit

ABADINSKY'S (2013) ATTRIBUTES

- ✗ **Hierarchy and ranks**
  Does not fit
- ✗ **Exclusive membership and rituals**
  Does not fit
- ✗ **Survives arrest of leaders**
  Does not fit
- ✓ **Profit-driven, specialized roles**
  Fits

Our verdict: organized white-collar crime, a legal company committing organized, transnational fraud

The brokers in the middle held the power



Network model Morselli (2009)
Power belongs to brokers who connect worlds that can't reach each other.

Patron–client Albini (1971)
Henry trades access to supply for a share of the profits.

Hierarchical model Cressey (1969)
Does not fit: no ranks, no code, no "family".

Corruption = Monopoly + Discretion − Accountability

Klitgaard (1988). Corruption: the abuse of entrusted power for private gain (Transparency International).

M MONOPOLY

Henry controls the only access to cheap Balkan ammunition, so everyone must pay him.

D DISCRETION

Officials, fixers and border agents in Jordan and Albania decide with little scrutiny; middlemen skim.

A LOW ACCOUNTABILITY

Wartime urgency: a company run by a man in his early twenties passes the Pentagon's vetting.

State-corporate crime (Kramer et al., 2002): the harm grew from a government policy of outsourcing war logistics to the lowest bidder. The crime–terror nexus appears too: a watch-listed dealer simply borrows a clean company name.

Act III: banned bullets, betrayal and a federal courtroom

SCENE 9 · DISCOVERY

Made in China

The ammunition is Chinese-made, banned under a US arms embargo and by the contract itself.

SCENE 10 · COVER-UP

Repackaging

Instead of reporting it, they have the rounds repacked to remove Chinese markings.

SCENE 11 · BETRAYAL

Partners turn

David is threatened in Albania, and Efraim cheats him. The friendship collapses.

SCENE 12 · VERDICT

Real sentences

Efraim: 4 years in prison. David cooperates: 7 months of house arrest.

The real case: exposed by journalists in 2008, prosecuted for fraud and conspiracy

Neutralization: how offenders silence their conscience

Sykes & Matza (1957): offenders know the rules, but use excuses to switch them off. In the film, every excuse sounds like normal business talk.

DENIAL OF INJURY

“The troops still get bullets that work. Who is harmed?”

CONDEMNATION OF THE CONDEMNERS

“The government buys from shady sources too.”

DENIAL OF RESPONSIBILITY

“We didn’t make the bullets. We just moved them.”

APPEAL TO HIGHER LOYALTIES

“I’m doing this for my family.”

Quotes paraphrase the characters’ attitudes; they are not verbatim lines.

Accurate in substance, exaggerated in style

Conceptual accuracy	4/5	Fits UNTOC, enterprise and network models closely
Factual accuracy	4/5	Contract, repackaging and sentences are true
Realism of tone	2/5	Comedy glamorizes fraud; threats in Albania invented
Systemic insight	2/5	Blames two men; skips state failure and Gërdec (26 killed)

Ratings are the group's assessment. Sources: Lawson (2015); Al Jazeera (2008). Henry Girard is a composite inspired by broker Heinrich Thomet.

THE FINAL CUT

Organized crime doesn't always carry guns. *Sometimes it sells them, with a government contract.*

THE ANSWER

AEY is organized crime under the UN definition, but not the mafia: it is organized white-collar crime.

THE LESSON FOR BANGLADESH

Big procurement relies on middlemen too. Vet contractors, disclose real owners, check where goods come from.

Thank you · *Questions?*

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